

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called The Seven Buddhas

Ārya-saptabuddhaka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 852 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་བ་དྲུག་པ་ཞེས་བརྒྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མདོ།

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called The Seven Buddhas, known in Sanskrit as Ārya-saptabuddhaka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra and in Tibetan as Phags pa sangs rgyas bdun pa zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, is a short discourse spoken by the Buddha at Mount Tise in the company of five hundred monks and five hundred bodhisattvas, including Maitreya, Ākāśagarbha, and Samantabhadra. It opens when the Blessed One sees a monk seized by a spirit and addresses his affliction, a setting typical of protective texts that offer remedies against harmful influences. The sūtra is Toh 852 in the Kangyur, where it is classed among the sūtras of the Mahāyāna, and its title points to a teaching centered on seven buddhas, whose names and power the discourse is meant to make known for the benefit of those in distress.

In the language of India: Ārya-saptabuddhaka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called The Seven Buddhas.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling on the summit of Mount Tise, in the abode of the gods, in the manner of a sage, and not very far away there was a great assembly of about five hundred monks. There were also five hundred bodhisattvas, among them the bodhisattva mahāsattva Maitreya, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Ākāśagarbha, Samantabhadra, Anantapuṣpa, and Samantapuṣpa. These and other bodhisattvas, each bound to only one more birth, were present together with a great many others.

Then, in that very forest on the mountain summit, the Blessed One saw a monk seized by a spirit. He was raving, naked, without clothing, with his arms raised, and weeping.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Ākāśagarbha arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, set his right knee upon the ground, and bowed toward the Blessed One with palms joined. He said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, who is this one in the midst of the sky who cries out "Kyi hud," and who is this other, a monk, naked and unclothed, with his hands raised?

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Ākāśagarbha: Ākāśagarbha, this one is afflicted by illness, and this other one also is afflicted by illness.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Ākāśagarbha said to the Blessed One: May the Blessed One teach the knowledge-mantra that completely pacifies all illness and turns back all spirits. Please speak it.

Then the Blessed One emanated seven buddhas. Thereupon six Tathāgatas appeared in the sky, and the seventh was the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni.

Then the Tathāgata Vipāśyin, seated in the sky above, spoke these foundational mantra words, for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illness, and to turn back all spirits.

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Tadyathā: Oṃ hala hala, hili hilāya, namo jagan mocanāya, namo namaḥ svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Vipāśyin said to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Ākāśagarbha: Ākāśagarbha, whoever holds this knowledge-mantra, recites it, or fully masters it will not be pierced by weapons in the body. He will not die from the afflictions of water and fire, or from illness. He will not die an untimely death. Even if he eats poison, it will become like food. If one recites it seven times over food and drink and then eats, no harm from others will arise. He will not be struck by any illness. He will live long. He will retain what he has heard. He will come to see the forms of the seven Tathāgatas.

Recite it into the ear of one wounded by a weapon, and give him mustard oil. For those afflicted with leprosy and swellings, if one gives oil mixed with mustard oil, blue lotus, shuti, and nyeu shingpa, all those illnesses will be healed.

This may also be applied to all rites.

Then the Tathāgata Uṣṇīṣa, abiding in the space above, spoke these root mantras for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illnesses, and for the repelling of all spirits.

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Oṃ pacapaca pācaya pācaya, sarvabhūtānāṃ, chindaya, kīlaya, vara vidyānāṃ svāhā.

Essence of Space, for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illnesses, for repelling faulty meditation and all evil dreams,

and for preventing untimely death, this has been spoken by buddhas in the hundreds of thousands of millions. I too now speak this essence. Hold it, Essence of Space. If anyone keeps this essence of mine in mind for three days and nights, no harm from others will arise for him. When he sleeps, he will see the form of the Tathāgata in his dreams. He will not die a wretched death. When he passes from this life, he will meet the Tathāgatas and bring them joy.

Next, other methods of this practice: for all illnesses, tie a cord. For one who has fallen ill through gathering, recite over butter from a nose-ointment and give it. One should bind the directions with water. With the cord one protects oneself. For the spirit afflictions of children, tie a blue cord. Recite seven times into the ear of one struck by a weapon. For other cases too, one should apply it according to one's own judgment.

Then the Tathāgata Sarvatrāṇa, abiding in the space above, spoke these root mantras for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illnesses, and for the repelling of all spirits.

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Oṃ kala kala, kili kili, kulu kulu, kulo tadhānānāṃ kuru, sarvagrahāṇāṃ svāhā.

Essence of Space, these root mantras were spoken by all the Tathāgatas of the Fortunate Aeon, past, future, and present, and I too now speak them. Essence of Space, hold these root mantras. Whoever holds them, reads them, or fully comprehends them will not be harmed in his body by weapons, nor by poison, nor by prepared poison. Epidemic illness will not take hold of him, nor water, nor untimely death, nor a wretched death, except for the obscurations of previous karma.

If any monk, nun, layman, or laywoman rises at dawn, washes the head, and recites this one hundred and eight times before the Tathāgata, all his karmic obscurations will be purified. Even those beings who hate him, and kings, will be the first to speak kindly to him. All beings will come under his influence. One should keep it in mind in all fearful situations. In all battles, fights, quarrels, and disputes, tie a white cord. For eye disease, make a cord from the milky tree and tie it on the ear. One who wishes to paralyze an army should make a fire offering of one hundred and eight pieces of rice stalk smeared with curd and honey. Rājānāṃ rājā mātra tāmbā vaśīkara tukāmena.

If one wishes to purify all obscurations and sins of oneself and all sentient beings, and to accomplish great glory and a great heap of wealth, one should kindle a fire with firewood of the milky tree and offer one thousand sesame

seeds into the fire.

One who wishes to purify all sins, who wishes to accomplish all knowledge-mantras, or who wishes to wash himself, should bathe with śuti, nala, khre, śirīṣa, Chinese incense, saffron, musk, Indra and Varuṇa herbs, the wood of awakening, and the crown of the mango. First he should fast for a day and a night before the Buddha, and set out a new vase. On the full moon, before an image of the Buddha, he should praise with the heart mantra one thousand and eight times, and then bathe.

One who wishes to render poison harmless should, before the Buddha, mix the leaves of the sengdeng tree with the dung of a cow, recite over them one hundred and eight times while speaking the name of the one concerned, and make a fire offering. Then the poison will become harmless. If this is applied to all rites against possessing spirits, against guardians, against elemental beings, and the like, one will dwell in happiness.

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Mithyādrṣṭivīśodhana, the Dispeller of Wrong Faith, abiding in the sky above, spoke these foundations of secret mantra for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illnesses, and for the repelling of all elemental beings.

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṅghāya. Namaḥ krakucchandāya. Tathāgatāya arhate samyaksaṃbuddhāya. Oṃ kaṭa kaṭa, kaṭha kaṭha, kiṭi kiṭi, kiṭhi kiṭhi, kiṭābaya namaḥ svāhā.

Essence of Space, Tathāgata, Arhat, Perfectly Awakened Buddha, the Dispeller of Wrong Faith, who has been proclaimed by as many Buddhas as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, and who is rejoiced in by them: take up this essence. If it is received, held, and fully understood, then in a later life monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen will find faith in the Three Jewels at that time, will bathe, and will make offerings to the Blessed One with flowers, incense, and perfumes. They will then recite this secret mantra one hundred and eight times, and they will remember their lives for seven lifetimes. Among the gods they will attain the greatness of a god. Or among humans they will become a wheel-turning king.

Or if one practices it according to the ritual, one will attain one's final human birth, and after dying and passing from here one will be born in the world realm of bliss. In this very life too, if one constantly recites it, one will be freed from all illnesses and will become a holder of what is heard. If one praises food and drink seven times and then eats and drinks, one will be freed from all

illnesses. If one wishes to quench thirst, one should wash all food with one thousand and eight recitations. For cutting off a lingering fever, one should use a copper needle. If one wishes to be freed from fighting, quarrels, and all bonds, then reciting it seven times will also constantly increase wealth. One will also be freed from all obstructors and misleading spirits.

If one wishes to see the Tathāgata, one should smear a maṇḍala on clean ground in a gathering place of the world, burn aloeswood incense, and recite one thousand and eight times. Then one lies down beside it with the pillow toward the east, and one will see the Tathāgata. Whatever one holds in mind, he will show it all. He will also show one's life, strength, and every victory and defeat.

Then the Tathāgata Kanakamuni (Golden Sage), abiding in the sky above, spoke these foundations of secret mantra for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illnesses, and for the repelling of all elemental beings.

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṅghāya. Namaḥ kanakamunaye. Tathāgatāya arhate samyaksaṃbuddhāya. Tadyathā: oṃ sara sara, sara sara, siri siri, siri siri.

Siri yā. Dhama dhama, dhama dhama. Dhuma dhuma, dhuma dhumāya. Namō namaḥ kanakamunaye. Tathāgatāya arhate samyaksaṃbuddhāya svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Kanakamuni spoke these words to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha. Ākāśagarbha, whoever holds this essence and constantly recites it will have no fear of weapons. Fire, water, and landslides will not bring about the time of death for such a person. All poisons, too, will become as harmless as food. Untimely death will not bring about the time of death. One will not die in a wretched state. One will have a long life and great enjoyments. One will constantly meet the Tathāgatas, and the Tathāgatas will bestow their blessing. If one recites it at the three times of day, all the obscurations of past karma will be purified.

If one wishes to free another from illness, one should offer sacrificial cake as one is able, and offer flour. One should fumigate with the incense of agarwood and then bathe in it. For leprosy, swellings, and liver tumors, one should grind soft shu-dag, mix it with honey, recite the mantra one thousand and eight times in the presence of the Buddha, the Blessed One, and smear it on; all leprosy will then be healed. For the fourth-day fever, one should recite one

thousand and eight times, in the presence of the Buddha, the Blessed One, over a garland of jasmine flowers, and bind it on the person's head; the fourth-day fever will then be healed. If one recites it into the ear of one who is marked, he will be freed from what causes forgetfulness. For those whose bodies are seized by worms, one should fumigate with flowers that have been offered to the Buddha. One should perform actions such as these. Of all such actions, it is said that this is the essential one.

Then the Tathāgata Kāśyapa, abiding in the sky above, spoke these foundations of secret mantra for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illnesses, and for the repelling of all elemental beings.

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṅghāya. Oṃ hara hara, hara hara, ha ha ha. Namaḥ kāśyapāya. Tathāgatāya arhate samyakṣambuddhāya. Siddhyantu mantrapadā svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Kāśyapa spoke these words to the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha. Ākāśagarbha, this essence was spoken by buddhas, the Blessed Ones, as numerous as the grains of sand in thirty-two Ganges rivers. Ākāśagarbha, you too should hold this essence and fully master it. Whoever holds it, reads it, or fully masters it, and recites it three times by day or by night, will, in brief, see the Tathāgata even in dreams. All the obscurations of that person's karma will also be purified, except for karma from before. It should also be applied to all kinds of actions.

For leprosy, skin disease, and the like, one should take flowers that have been offered to the Buddha, recite over them one thousand and eight times in the presence of the Buddha, and then, reading the mantra and washing with them, one will be healed. For headache, one should place flowers offered to the Buddha before the Buddha and recite seven times in the Buddha's presence. It should be applied in all cases.

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, abiding in the sky above, spoke these knowledge-mantras for the benefit of all sentient beings.

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṅghāya. Tadyathā: ghume ghume, mahāghume. Tale tale, mahātale. Cale cale, mahācale. Dhure dhure, mahādhure. Tiri tiri.

Mahātiri. Kili kili, mahākili. Curu curu, mahācuru. Mili mili, mahāmili. Tili tili, mahātili. Dhume dhume, mahādhume. Cale cale, mahācale. Khiri khiri,

mahākhiri. Cili cili, mahācili. Svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Śākyamuni spoke these words to the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, to dispel diseases of the head, one should perform the rite with a blade and with the palm of the hand. To turn back clouds, one should perform it with a twig of the karavīra tree. Poison is to be treated with water. The other rites should likewise be performed. One should apply them in accordance with the ritual of bathing. By means of every ritual, one should apply them in every case."

When the Blessed One had spoken in this way, the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha, rejoiced, and praised what the Blessed One had said.

Thus ends the Mahāyāna sūtra called The Noble Seven Buddhas.

Translator's Notes

- Mount Tise is Mount Kailāśa. "Bound to only one more birth" renders skyé ba gcig gis thogs pa, a bodhisattva of a single remaining birth. The Tibetan text has one name for the sixth Tathāgata who speaks, Vipaśyīn (Rnam par gzigs), which I have kept. The mantra is rendered in its Sanskritized transliteration; its syllables are partly obscure and are not translated. The plant names shuti and nyeu shingpa are left untranslated because their botanical identification is uncertain, and "mustard oil" for sna ma'i mar is a probable but not certain identification.
- The Tibetan text appears corrupt in places, and the translation of those lines is tentative. The line about one "fallen ill through gathering," the "butter from a nose-ointment," and the phrase "rice stalk" are uncertain. The mantra syllables are given in reconstructed Sanskrit and are partly unclear; the closing phrase after the army-paralysis rite is likely a garbled mantra. The spelling "Sarvatrāṇa" for the second Tathāgata, rendered from "All-Protector," is reconstructed. The "milky tree" (shing o ma can) is a plant name I have kept literal, since its botanical identity is uncertain.
- The Tibetan name "Dispeller of Wrong Faith" is rendered as Mithyādrṣṭivīśodhana on a reconstructed basis; the Sanskrit is uncertain. Several plant names (śuti, nala, khre, sengdeng, and others) are transliterated or left unidentified because their botanical identification is doubtful. In the first mantra, "Krakucchandāya" is rendered as written, and the mantra syllables are given in plain transliteration. The phrase about being "a holder of what is heard" renders the Tibetan literally, meaning retention of learning. The Tibetan opens the second mantra's buddha as "golden sage," corresponding to Kanakamuni, whose name appears in the mantra itself.
- The Tibetan mantra transliterations are rendered in normalized Sanskrit form; several syllables are corrupt in the Tibetan and the reconstruction is approximate. The Tibetan "Golden Sage" for Kanakamuni and "Protector of Light" for Kāśyapa are given in their Sanskrit names, following the preceding passage. Some medical and ritual terms in the healing instructions are uncertain, notably "shu-dag" (an unidentified plant or substance, left transliterated), the "marked" person whose ear is recited into, and "what causes forgetfulness"; the sentence about the "essential action" is also obscure. "Jasmine" for the flower garland is a probable but not certain identification.
- The passage opens mid-mantra, with the first syllable fragmentary, so I have rendered it as

the continuation of the closing line "Tiri tiri" of the preceding passage, reading it as "mahātiri." The mantra is transliterated, not translated, and its Sanskrit forms are reconstructed from the Tibetan transcription. The instructions for the rites are terse and elliptical. "With a blade and with the palm of the hand" and "poison is to be treated with water" follow the Tibetan as written. The tree named is the karavīra, usually identified with oleander.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.